

Irrationality after One Stabilization of Universally CH_0 -Trivial Cubic Threefolds

Tavis Rudd

August 2026

Abstract

Does universal CH_0 -triviality force rationality after stabilization? We construct a non-isotrivial one-parameter family of smooth cubic threefolds X_b for which X_b is universally CH_0 -trivial but $X_b \times \mathbf{P}^1$ is irrational. More generally, we prove that $X \times \mathbf{P}^1$ is irrational for every smooth cubic threefold X .

The cycle argument proves an all-degree integral saturation theorem for marked finite-etale graph quotients of elliptic powers: divided powers of the marked divisor lattice are ordinary divisor products. The six-axis intermediate Jacobians in the nonstandard A_5 -invariant cubic pencil satisfy its hypotheses. Voisin's theorem gives universal CH_0 -triviality on every smooth fibre.

For irrationality, we count primitive-sixth eigenvalues of framed formal monodromy on the numerical small even quantum connection. Divisor tags make Iritani's blowup formula compatible with a possibly noninjective center specialization. The count is a birational invariant through dimension four and equals two for a cubic. Thus the cycle-theoretic and quantum detectors diverge on the same smooth fourfolds.

Keywords. cubic threefold; universal CH_0 -triviality; irrationality; intermediate Jacobian; quantum connection; weak factorization.

1 Introduction

A smooth projective variety is universally CH_0 -trivial if the degree map

$$\deg : CH_0(Y_L) \longrightarrow \mathbf{Z}$$

is an isomorphism for every field extension $L/\mathbf{C}$. This condition is a central consequence of stable rationality, and its failure is a standard stable-rationality obstruction. Its validity, however, need not provide a rational parametrization. We ask how far that gap can persist after one explicit stabilization.

Our examples are fourfolds of the form $Y = X \times \mathbf{P}^1$, where X is a smooth cubic threefold in the nonstandard A_5 -invariant pencil. Two independent mechanisms act on the same Y . The intermediate Jacobian of X has an algebraic primitive minimal class; this gives universal CH_0 -triviality. The small even quantum connection of every smooth cubic has primitive-sixth framed formal monodromy; Iritani's quantum blowup formula shows that its multiplicity survives one stabilization.

Theorem 1.1 (Separation after one stabilization). *Let W_5 be the five-dimensional irreducible A_5 -module, and let B° be the smooth locus inside*

$$\mathbf{P}((\mathrm{Sym}^3 W_5^*)^{A_5}).$$

For the resulting family $\mathcal{X} \rightarrow B^\circ$ and every $b \in B^\circ(\mathbf{C})$,

$\mathcal{X}_b$ is universally CH_0 -trivial, $\mathcal{X}_b \times \mathbf{P}^1$ is universally CH_0 -trivial and irrational.

The family is non-isotrivial in coarse moduli.

The irrationality statement does not depend on the symmetry of the pencil.

Theorem 1.2 (One-step irrationality). *For every smooth complex cubic threefold X , the fourfold $X \times \mathbf{P}^1$ is irrational.*

The same invariant also gives one-step irrationality for every smooth prime Fano threefold of genus eight; see Corollary 4.12.

The invariant cubic space in Theorem 1.1 is two-dimensional. Indeed, the character of W_5 is $(5, 1, -1, 0, 0)$ on the classes $1, 2A, 3A, 5A, 5B$. The symmetric-cube character formula gives

$$\dim(\mathrm{Sym}^3 W_5^*)^{A_5} = 2.$$

Thus its projectivization is a pencil with connected smooth locus B° . Hartlieb denotes it by M_{H_1} ; it is not the component associated with $\mathbf{1} \oplus W_4$ [8, Lemma 5.5].

We do not claim that X is stably irrational. From the second stabilization onward, weak-factorization centers can themselves have cubic dimension, and the low-dimensional exclusion used here no longer applies.

How the two proofs meet

The cycle argument starts from six elliptic quotients of the Fano surface. Their Rosati Gram matrix is $6I - J$, and the geometric kernel lies in the exotic two-point complement of $\mathbf{P}^1(\mathbf{F}_2) \subset \mathbf{P}^1(\mathbf{F}_4)$. Its local graph slopes are finite etale at two and three. The graph equations then make the descended divisor lattices rank-one generated. Since rank-one coefficient divisors have square zero, $\Theta^4/4!$ is an ordinary integral divisor product.

The quantum argument counts primitive sixth-root eigenvalues of framed formal monodromy on the numerical small even quantum connection. Iritani's operation formulas make this count additive through weak factorization; divisor tags repair a potentially noninjective center specialization. Cai's cubic calculation is nonzero, while every center of dimension at most two contributes zero. The special A_5 -geometry enters only in the cycle argument; the quantum theorem applies to every smooth cubic threefold.

Relation with earlier rationality results

Clemens and Griffiths proved that every smooth complex cubic threefold is irrational by means of its intermediate Jacobian [5]. That obstruction does not by itself control a product with projective space, and stable rationality of smooth cubic threefolds remains open. Cai recently recovered irrationality from the primitive-sixth-root formal monodromy of the cubic quantum connection [4]. Iritani and Iritani–Koto prove the quantum D -module decompositions for blowups and projective bundles [10, 12]; Katzarkov–Kontsevich–Pantev–Yu identify the nef-canonical normal form used for low-dimensional centers [13]. Theorem 1.2 combines these inputs at the next dimension.

On the cycle side, Voisin reduces universal CH_0 -triviality of a cubic threefold to algebraicity of the primitive minimal class of its intermediate Jacobian [18]. Beckmann–de Gaay Fortman place such minimal classes in a general integral-Fourier framework [3]. For the very general cubic threefold the minimal class is not algebraic: every curve class on the intermediate Jacobian is an even multiple of it, so a very general cubic threefold admits no

decomposition of the diagonal [6, Theorem 1.3 and Corollary 1.4]. What Voisin's criterion leaves is the countable union of moduli subvarieties on which the class is algebraic; Theorem 3.5 places an explicit exceptional family inside that union. The six elliptic quotients supplied by Roulleau and the special period locus isolated by Hartlieb make the class explicit: it belongs to the ordinary integral divisor-product lattice for every smooth member of the nonstandard A_5 -pencil.

Proof map

Section 2 computes the six-axis polarization and identifies the exotic cubic gluing. Section 3 proves the local divisor-product theorem and applies it to the primitive minimal class. Section 4 proves Theorem 1.2 from formal monodromy and weak factorization. The final section combines the two detectors and records the exact scope boundary.

2 The six-axis polarization and the exotic packet

Let Ω be the six conjugate D_5 -subgroups of A_5 , equivalently the six Sylow-5 subgroups with their normalizers, and put

$$H_p = \text{Aug}(\mathbf{F}_p^\Omega) / \langle \mathbf{1} \rangle \quad (p = 2, 3).$$

The modules H_2, H_3 are simple, with $\text{End}_{A_5}(H_2) = \mathbf{F}_4$ and $\text{End}_{A_5}(H_3) = \mathbf{F}_3$ [9, the A_5 matrix-representation rows in characteristic two, $\text{GF}(4)$ -dimension two (IDs a,b) and $\text{GF}(2)$ -dimension four (IDs a,b), and in characteristic three, $\text{GF}(3)$ -dimension four].

The six axes arise from the Fano surface. Let S be the Fano surface of a smooth member of the A_5 -pencil and $(J, \Theta) = \text{Alb}(S)$ its intermediate Jacobian. Each of the six D_5 -subgroups gives an elliptic quotient $q_H : J \rightarrow E_H$ and its Rosati dual $i_H : E_H \rightarrow J$.

Generic non-CM axis. Hartlieb's elliptic isogeny factor, and hence every generic six-axis elliptic quotient, is non-CM. Indeed, a CM endomorphism has a fixed imaginary-quadratic order, so the generic j -invariant is a root of its Hilbert class polynomial and is constant. After a finite base change the elliptic factor would then be isotrivial. Hartlieb's isogeny $J_b \sim E_b^5$ would put the whole intermediate-Jacobian family in the countable isogeny class of one fixed abelian variety. The image of an algebraic curve in a moduli space cannot be both positive-dimensional and countable. This contradicts the fact that the closure of the intermediate-Jacobian image is a one-dimensional special subvariety [8, Proposition 5.7 and Remark 5.8]. Since the generic intermediate Jacobian is isotypic to E_b^5 , each nonzero elliptic quotient is isogenous to E_b , and so is non-CM as well.

Proposition 2.1 (Six-axis polarization). *After coherent identification of the elliptic factors, the Rosati Gram matrix of the six maps is*

$$G_6 = 6I_6 - J_6.$$

Any five axes therefore give an isogeny $E^5 \rightarrow J$ whose pulled-back polarization has Smith type $(1, 6, 6, 6, 6)$.

Proof. We recall the numerical passage from Roulleau's genus-two configuration to the six elliptic fibres. Let $D_g \subset S$ be the curve indexed by an involution $g \in A_5$, put $D_{\text{tot}} = \sum_g D_g$, and, for a dihedral subgroup H of order ten, put

$$F_H = \sum_{g \in H, g^2=1} D_g.$$

Rouleau proves that F_H is a fibre of $S \rightarrow E_H$ [17, Theorem 11(D)], so $F_H^2 = 0$. His intersection table has $D_g^2 = -4$, and distinct curves meet with multiplicity zero, two, or one when the product of their labels has order two, three, or five, respectively; Lemma 14 proves that these values are constant in the corresponding families [17, Lemma 14, Corollary 16, and (3.1)]. Among the 105 unordered pairs of involutions, the product orders two, three, and five occur 15, 30, 60 times. Hence

$$D_{\text{tot}}^2 = 15(-4) + 2(30 \cdot 2 + 60 \cdot 1) = 180.$$

Every involution belongs to two of the six dihedral subgroups, and therefore $\sum_H F_H = 2D_{\text{tot}}$. Two-transitivity on the six subgroups now gives

$$30(F_H \cdot F_{H'}) = (2D_{\text{tot}})^2 = 720, \quad F_H \cdot F_{H'} = 24 \quad (H \neq H').$$

By the preceding generic non-CM argument, the elliptic factor has only integer endomorphisms. After coherent identification of the generic elliptic quotients, two-transitivity makes the Rosati matrix have diagonal d and off-diagonal m . Put

$$D_H = q_H^*[0] \in \text{NS}(J), \quad N_H = i_H q_H \in \text{End}(J).$$

Then $D_H|_S = F_H$, and N_H is the Rosati endomorphism attached to D_H . Coherent identification gives $q_H i_H = [d]$ and $q_H i_{H'} = [m]$ for $H \neq H'$. The invariant sum of the six axis maps vanishes because the five-dimensional constituent has no trivial summand; composing with q_H gives $d + 5m = 0$. The minimal-class identity $[S] = \Theta^3/3!$ [5], together with the polarized Riemann–Roch trace formula

$$\frac{\alpha\beta\Theta^{g-2}}{(g-2)!} = \text{tr}(N_\alpha)\text{tr}(N_\beta) - \text{tr}(N_\alpha N_\beta),$$

obtained by polarizing the reduced-norm Riemann–Roch polynomial [7, Theorem 4.1], gives the following identities. Here tr is the degree-five trace in the coefficient representation—the trace entering that reduced norm—rather than the degree-ten trace on rational first homology:

$$\text{tr}(N_H) = d, \quad \text{tr}(N_H N_{H'}) = m^2, \quad F_H F_{H'} = d^2 - m^2.$$

Thus $d^2 - m^2 = 24$. Together with $d + 5m = 0$ and $d > 0$, this forces $(d, m) = (5, -1)$, hence $G_6 = 6I - J$. A five-by-five minor has Smith form $(1, 6, 6, 6, 6)$. $\square$

Let B° be the connected smooth locus of the nonstandard A_5 -pencil, and let $\mathcal{J} \rightarrow B^\circ$ be its relative intermediate Jacobian.

Lemma 2.2 (Relative six-axis source). *There are an elliptic scheme $\mathcal{E} \rightarrow B^\circ$ and a relative isogeny*

$$f : \mathcal{A} := \mathcal{E} \otimes_{\mathbf{Z}} (\mathbf{Z}^\Omega / \mathbf{Z}\mathbf{1}) \longrightarrow \mathcal{J}$$

which is A_5 -equivariant. The quotient lattice carries the form induced by $6I_6 - J_6$; both the source and this form carry their natural S_6 -action. Moreover,

$$f^* \lambda_\Theta = \lambda_{\mathcal{A}}. \tag{2.1}$$

After omitting one axis, $\mathcal{A} \simeq \mathcal{E}^5$ and this form has matrix $6I_5 - J_5$. For $p = 2, 3$, put $\mathcal{V}_p = \mathcal{E}[p]$. The p -primary kernel of the source polarization has a natural A_5 -equivariant symplectic description

$$\mathcal{D}_p \simeq H_p \otimes_{\mathbf{F}_p} \mathcal{V}_p \quad (p = 2, 3). \tag{2.2}$$

The p -primary part $\mathcal{K}_p$ of $\ker f$ is an A_5 -stable relative maximal isotropic subgroup of $\mathcal{D}_p$.

Proof. For $H \in \Omega$, the integral norm $n_H = \sum_{h \in H} h$ is a relative endomorphism of $\mathcal{J}$. Its action on rational first homology is ten times the projector onto the H -fixed summand. Fibrewise, Hartlieb's character calculation and isogeny decomposition give $H^1(J, \mathbf{Q}) \simeq W_5 \otimes H^1(E, \mathbf{Q})$, and hence the self-product of an elliptic curve through the five-dimensional module W_5 [8, Lemma 5.5 and Remark 5.8]. Since $\dim W_5^H = 1$, the fixed summand has rank two. More concretely, $n_H^2 = 10n_H$. The scheme-theoretic image of a homomorphism of abelian schemes in characteristic zero is an abelian subscheme, and its quotient factorization commutes with base change [2, Theorem A]. Thus the scheme-theoretic image $\mathcal{E}_H \subset \mathcal{J}$ is an abelian scheme of relative dimension one. It is therefore an elliptic scheme. Since $hn_H = n_H$ for every $h \in H$, the subgroup H acts trivially on $\mathcal{E}_H$. Moreover $N_{A_5}(H) = H$, so transport by an element carrying H to H' is independent of the chosen transporter. The six elliptic schemes are therefore coherently isomorphic; fix one of them as $\mathcal{E}$.

Write $i_H : \mathcal{E} \rightarrow \mathcal{J}$ for the transported primitive inclusions. On the geometric generic fibre, Hartlieb's isogeny decomposition identifies $\mathrm{Hom}^0(E, J)$ with the irreducible module W_5 . The coherently transported maps $(i_H)_{H \in \Omega}$ form one A_5 -orbit, so their sum is invariant. Since $W_5^{A_5} = 0$, that sum is zero. The connected smooth curve B° is integral, $\mathcal{E}$ is integral, and $\mathcal{J}$ is separated. Equality on the generic fibre therefore gives $\sum_H i_H = 0$ over B° . Hence $(i_H)_{H \in \Omega}$ descends from $\mathcal{E}^\Omega$ to the displayed map $f : \mathcal{A} \rightarrow \mathcal{J}$, and the construction is A_5 -equivariant.

Roulleau constructs the D_5 -fibration from an Albanese quotient $q_H : J \rightarrow E_H$ by a connected four-dimensional abelian subvariety [17, Lemma 17 and the following proof of Theorem 11(D)]. Thus $F_H = q_H^*[0]|_S$. The connected kernel makes the Rosati dual of q_H a primitive inclusion, and its image is the unique H -fixed elliptic subvariety. It therefore agrees, up to an automorphism of the target elliptic curve, with the norm image $\mathcal{E}_H \hookrightarrow \mathcal{J}$. This also identifies the norm-image axis, up to isogeny, with Hartlieb's generic elliptic isogeny factor. Consequently the fibre classes in Proposition 2.1 compute these relative homomorphisms, rather than merely isogenous quotients. On the generic non-CM fibre they give diagonal entry 5 and off-diagonal entry -1 . Applying the same generic-density and separatedness argument to these homomorphisms gives the identities over B° , hence (2.1). Choosing any five coordinate classes identifies the quotient lattice with $\mathbf{Z}^5$, where its matrix is $6I_5 - J_5$. Since this has Smith type $(1, 6, 6, 6, 6)$, the source polarization is nondegenerate, so f is a finite flat isogeny. From $\lambda_{\mathcal{A}} = f^\vee \lambda_\Theta f$ one gets

$$|\ker \lambda_{\mathcal{A}}| = 6^8, \quad |\ker f| = \deg f = 6^4.$$

For $x, y \in \ker f$, functoriality of the polarization commutator pairing gives $e_{\lambda_{\mathcal{A}}}(x, y) = e_{\lambda_\Theta}(fx, fy) = 1$. Thus $\ker f$ is isotropic and has square-root order in $\ker \lambda_{\mathcal{A}}$, hence is maximal isotropic. Its p -primary part has fibrewise order p^4 for $p = 2, 3$.

For $p = 2, 3$, the primary discriminant local system is

$$\mathcal{D}_p = \ker(6I_6 - J_6 : \mathcal{A}[p] \longrightarrow \mathcal{A}^\vee[p]).$$

Modulo p , the radical quotient of the induced coefficient form is canonically

$$\mathrm{Aug}(\mathbf{F}_p^\Omega)/\langle \mathbf{1} \rangle = H_p.$$

The form on this coefficient discriminant is the normalized form

$$b_p(\bar{x}, \bar{y}) = \frac{1}{p} x^\mathbf{t} (6I_6 - J_6) y \pmod{p} = \begin{cases} \bar{x} \cdot \bar{y}, & p = 2, \\ -\bar{x} \cdot \bar{y}, & p = 3. \end{cases} \quad (2.3)$$

For augmentation lifts, the product of the coordinate sums is divisible by p^2 , which proves the displayed formulas. They are unchanged by adding the constant vector or p times

an integral vector. The dot product on the augmentation module has radical exactly the constant line, so b_p is nondegenerate on H_p ; b_2 is alternating and b_3 is symmetric. Tensoring with the Weil pairing on $\mathcal{V}_p$ gives (2.2) as a symplectic isomorphism. Since f is A_5 -equivariant, each $\mathcal{K}_p$ is A_5 -stable. The preceding order and isotropy calculation makes it a relative maximal isotropic subgroup of this rank-eight local system. $\square$

Proposition 2.3 (Principal gluing packet). *The A_5 -stable two-primary principal kernels of the six-axis source are parametrized by*

$$\mathbf{P}^1(\mathbf{F}_4) = \mathbf{P}^1(\mathbf{F}_2) \sqcup \{\omega, \omega^2\}.$$

The three $\mathbf{F}_2$ -rational kernels are S_6 -stable. Each of the other two has stabilizer exactly A_5 , and the outer normalizer exchanges them. The intermediate Jacobian of the nonstandard A_5 -cubic component uses the latter pair. The A_5 -stable three-primary kernels form $\mathbf{P}^1(\mathbf{F}_3)$; after choosing a complementary symplectic ruling, each is a scalar graph.

Proof. At two the coefficient discriminant is the simple four-dimensional $\mathbf{F}_2 A_5$ -module H_2 , whose commutant is $\mathbf{F}_4$. The full discriminant is the semisimple module $H_2 \otimes_{\mathbf{F}_2} \mathbf{F}_2^2 \simeq H_2^{\oplus 2}$. Every stable half is therefore one copy of H_2 , and Schur's lemma identifies such submodules with the one-dimensional $\mathbf{F}_4$ -subspaces of $\mathbf{F}_4^2$. This gives $\mathbf{P}^1(\mathbf{F}_4)$.

Here is the polarization check explicitly. Identify the coefficient heart with the natural two-dimensional $\mathbf{F}_4$ -module. The trace-determinant form is a nonzero invariant alternating form. Relative to it, the normalized form b_2 of (2.3) differs by a nonzero scalar in $\mathbf{F}_4$; rescaling an $\mathbf{F}_4$ -basis absorbs that scalar because squaring permutes $\mathbf{F}_4^\times$. We may therefore put

$$b(x, y) = \text{Tr}_{\mathbf{F}_4/\mathbf{F}_2} \det(x, y).$$

On two multiplicity copies use

$$\Omega((x, y), (x', y')) = b(x, y') + b(y, x').$$

Every scalar $a \in \mathbf{F}_4$ is self-adjoint for b , since $b(ax, y) = b(x, ay)$. Thus the vertical line and all four graphs Γ_a are isotropic of half dimension. The five module-theoretic possibilities are exactly the five polarized gluings; no further quadratic condition removes the exotic pair.

The simplex group acts on both multiplicity copies of the coefficient heart over $\mathbf{F}_2$. Hence the three lines defined over $\mathbf{F}_2$ retain S_6 . The stabilizer of an exotic graph is equally intrinsic. A permutation that fixes Γ_ω commutes with ω , hence is $\mathbf{F}_4$ -linear on the two-dimensional $\mathbf{F}_4$ -space H_2 . If its determinant is $d \in \mathbf{F}_4^\times$, preservation of b says

$$\text{Tr}_{\mathbf{F}_4/\mathbf{F}_2}(dz) = \text{Tr}_{\mathbf{F}_4/\mathbf{F}_2}(z) \quad (z \in \mathbf{F}_4).$$

The trace pairing is nondegenerate, so $d = 1$. It therefore lies in $\text{SL}_2(4)$, of order 60. The given A_5 already has that order and lies in the stabilizer, proving equality. The odd coset in its order-120 normalizer is semilinear and applies field Frobenius, so it exchanges ω and ω^2 .

To pass from the generic fibre to the family, put

$$\mathcal{P} = \mathbf{P}_{\mathbf{F}_4}(\mathbf{F}_4 \otimes_{\mathbf{F}_2} \mathcal{V}_2).$$

By Lemma 2.2, this is the five-sheet local system of A_5 -stable principal halves. It has the degree-three sub-local system $\mathcal{P}_{\text{rat}} = \mathbf{P}_{\mathbf{F}_2}(\mathcal{V}_2)$ and the degree-two complement $\mathcal{P}_{\text{ex}}$. Here H_2 , together with its commutant $\mathbf{F}_4$, is constant, while monodromy acts only on $\mathcal{V}_2$. Its

action is therefore $\mathbf{F}_4$ -linear, not semilinear, and factors through $\mathrm{GL}_2(\mathbf{F}_2)$; in particular it preserves both subsets. The relative kernel $\mathcal{K}_2$ gives a section of $\mathcal{P}$.

At the geometric generic point this section cannot be rational. Otherwise the natural faithful S_6 -action on $\mathcal{A} = \mathcal{E} \otimes (\mathbf{Z}^\Omega / \mathbf{Z}\mathbf{1})$, which is the identity on $\mathcal{E}$ tensored with the faithful permutation action on the quotient lattice, would preserve the rational kernel: under (2.2) it acts on H_2 and trivially on $\mathcal{V}_2$, so every member of $\mathcal{P}_{\mathrm{rat}}$ is S_6 -stable. At three, the analogous coefficient heart H_3 is simple and $\mathrm{End}_{A_5}(H_3) = \mathbf{F}_3$. The semisimple module $H_3^{\oplus 2}$ has stable halves parametrized by $\mathbf{P}^1(\mathbf{F}_3)$. The tensor pairing is b_3 times the alternating multiplicity pairing, so the three affine scalar graphs and the vertical line are all maximal isotropic. The natural S_6 -action is the same on both multiplicity copies, so it fixes every one of these four lines. Since $|\ker f| = 6^4$, its two- and three-primary parts exhaust the kernel. The full kernel would therefore be S_6 -stable. Since this action preserves $6I_6 - J_6$, it would descend through the principally polarized quotient. It would act faithfully: if a source automorphism acts trivially on the quotient, the image of its difference from the identity is both connected and contained in the finite isogeny kernel, hence zero. Strong Torelli gives an exact sequence [8, Theorem 3.1]

$$1 \longrightarrow \{\pm 1\} \longrightarrow \mathrm{Aut}(J, \Theta) \longrightarrow \mathrm{Aut}(X) \longrightarrow 1.$$

The kernel of the resulting map from S_6 to $\mathrm{Aut}(X)$ would be a normal subgroup of order at most two; it is trivial. Thus S_6 would act faithfully on a smooth cubic threefold. This contradicts the classification of faithful automorphism groups [8, Theorem 2.1]. Five of the six listed ambient groups have order smaller than $|S_6| = 720$. The remaining group is $(\mathbf{Z}/3\mathbf{Z})^4 \rtimes S_5$, of order 9720, which is not divisible by 720. None can contain S_6 . The section is therefore generically in $\mathcal{P}_{\mathrm{ex}}$. Its inverse image is open and closed in the connected base B° , so every smooth fibre has exotic two-primary kernel. The same calculation at three gives the four lines parametrized by $\mathbf{P}^1(\mathbf{F}_3)$; choosing any complementary line as the vertical ruling makes the selected half an affine scalar graph. $\square$

For the cycle-theoretic argument, the unordered pair is enough. Both members act on the heart with the same squarefree minimal polynomial $t^2 + t + 1$. Theorem 3.5 uses only the conclusion that the geometric kernel is not one of the three $\mathbf{F}_2$ -rational gluings. At three it uses only scalarity of the possible A_5 -stable graphs, not the finer monodromy selection.

Hartlieb proves that the closure of its intermediate-Jacobian image is a one-dimensional special subvariety [8, Proposition 5.7]. Since the cubic period map is a locally closed embedding, the resulting smooth family is non-isotrivial. Only this landing and nonconstancy are used below; no identification of compactified parameter curves is needed for the separation theorem.

3 Integral divisor products and the primitive minimal class

Let (A, Θ) be a principally polarized abelian variety of dimension g . Put

$$P_A^k = \mathrm{im}\left(\mathrm{Sym}^k \mathrm{NS}(A) \longrightarrow H^{2k}(A, \mathbf{Z})\right), \quad \gamma_A = \frac{\Theta^{g-1}}{(g-1)!}.$$

The class $D^k/k!$ of a divisor on an abelian variety is integral. The question here is whether these divided powers already belong to the smaller lattice P_A^k generated by ordinary products of integral divisors.

For quotients of elliptic powers, this question is controlled by the valuation pattern of the descended coefficient forms. The main local result of this section says that finite-etale graph

slopes force all divided powers of the prescribed graph divisor lattice into ordinary products, in every degree. The proof has two steps: the graph equations produce a symmetric matrix-of-ideals lattice, and a midpoint inequality makes that lattice rank-one generated. Rank-one coefficient divisors have square zero, so their divided powers expand without factorials. The six-axis application supplies the primitive minimal class needed below.

3.1 A local graph theorem

Work over a complete unramified discrete valuation ring O , with uniformizer p . Fix an elliptic curve E , an isogeny $q : E^n \rightarrow Y$ to a principally polarized abelian variety, and extend the p -adic coefficient lattices to O . A symmetric matrix $A \in \text{Sym}_n(O)$ denotes the standard coefficient divisor D_A on E^n , generated by coordinate and Poincare divisors. Define the prescribed graph-divisor lattice and its ordinary product image by

$$\begin{aligned} N_{\text{gr}}(q, O) &= \{D \in \text{NS}(Y) \otimes O : q^*D = D_A \text{ for some } A \in \text{Sym}_n(O)\}, \\ P_{\text{gr}}^k &= \text{im}\left(\text{Sym}^k N_{\text{gr}}(q, O) \longrightarrow H^{2k}(Y, \mathbf{Z}_p) \otimes O\right). \end{aligned} \quad (3.1)$$

Because q^* is injective on torsion-free cohomology, we identify $N_{\text{gr}}(q, O)$ with the symmetric matrices whose coefficient divisors descend through q . This is the prescribed lattice even when E has complex multiplication; no extra CM divisor is included.

Suppose the pullback coefficient polarization on the elliptic-power source is

$$G = PB, \quad P = \bigoplus_a p^a I_{M_a}, \quad B = \frac{1}{a} B_a, \quad (3.2)$$

where each B_a is unimodular. A *marked finite-etale graph presentation* consists of a symplectic ruling of the primary polarization kernel in which $\ker q$ is the graph of an endomorphism T , with the following properties: T preserves the depth summands M_a ,

$$T^t B^{-1} = B^{-1} T \quad \text{or, equivalently,} \quad B T^t = T B, \quad (3.3)$$

and the algebra generated by T modulo p^a is finite etale on every positive-depth summand. Thus adjointness is taken for the dual coefficient form B^{-1} . No etaleness is required on M_0 .

After a finite unramified extension splitting these etale algebras, the positive-depth summands decompose orthogonally into blocks

$$L_i = L_{a_i, \lambda_i}, \quad T_i = t_i I + p^{a_i} S_i, \quad (3.4)$$

with S_i integral. Indeed, completeness lifts the primitive idempotents of each split finite-etale quotient to idempotents in the algebra generated by T . They are polynomials in T , so (3.3) makes them self-adjoint for B^{-1} . Their images are therefore mutually orthogonal for B^{-1} , and hence for B ; on each image, T is scalar modulo the corresponding power p^{a_i} . We keep the unit part as one block. Write $\delta_{ij} = v_p(t_j - t_i)$, with $v_p(0) = \infty$, for two positive-depth blocks.

Lemma 3.1 (The graph coefficient lattice). *In the split basis, the coefficient lattice of descended graph divisors is the symmetric matrix-of-ideals lattice whose diagonal block i has depth p^{a_i} and whose (i, j) -block has depth*

$$e_{ij} = \max\{a_i, a_j, a_i + a_j - \delta_{ij}\}. \quad (3.5)$$

For the unit block and a positive-depth block j , one has $e_{0j} = a_j$. In particular,

$$e_{ij} \geq \max(a_i, a_j) \geq \left\lceil \frac{a_i + a_j}{2} \right\rceil. \quad (3.6)$$

Proof. Choose the symplectic basis determined by the marked ruling and the depth decomposition. Adjoining the graph generators to the source homology lattice gives the quotient lattice, and in these coordinates the change-of-lattice matrix is

$$C = \begin{pmatrix} P^{-1} & P^{-1}T \\ 0 & I \end{pmatrix}.$$

A coefficient alternating form descends precisely when its matrix transported by C is integral. For a symmetric source coefficient A , direct multiplication gives

$$C \begin{pmatrix} 0 & A \\ -A & 0 \end{pmatrix} C^t = \begin{pmatrix} P^{-1}(AT^t - TA)P^{-1} & P^{-1}A \\ -AP^{-1} & 0 \end{pmatrix}. \quad (3.7)$$

Thus descent is equivalent to the integrality of the three displayed nonzero blocks. Here $A = A^t$ is a symmetric coefficient bilinear form in this normalization. On two positive-depth blocks $L_i \times L_j$, the two off-diagonal blocks first force A_{ij} to have depth $\max(a_i, a_j)$. Substituting $T_i = t_i I + p^{a_i} S_i$ into the upper-left block leaves the additional condition

$$p^{-a_i - a_j} (t_j - t_i) A_{ij} \in M_{r_i \times r_j}(O);$$

the terms containing S_i, S_j are already integral. Intersecting the two conditions gives (3.5). Changing a scalar lift cannot change its maximum. Pairing the unsplit unit block with L_j gives $e_{0j} = a_j$ directly from (3.7), and (3.6) follows. $\square$

The inequality (3.6) is the valuation shadow of the tropical positive semidefinite cone studied by Yu [19]. We need the following signed integral lift of that inequality; in particular, no division by two is permitted.

Lemma 3.2 (Rank-one generation over a DVR). *Let L be a symmetric matrix-of-ideals lattice over O , with diagonal depths p^{a_i} and cross depths $p^{e_{ij}}$. Then L is generated by its rank-one forms if and only if*

$$2e_{ij} \geq a_i + a_j \quad (i \neq j). \quad (3.8)$$

Proof. If $cvv^t \in L$, the two diagonal conditions imply

$$v_p(cv_i v_j) \geq \left\lceil \frac{a_i + a_j}{2} \right\rceil.$$

Hence rank-one forms cannot generate a shallower cross ideal.

Conversely, fix a generator $p^e(uv^t + vu^t)$ of a cross block. Choose $x \geq a_i$ with $y = 2e - x \geq a_j$. The integers x, y have the same parity. If $t = \min(x, y)$, write $x = t + 2r$ and $y = t + 2s$. Then

$$p^t(p^r u + p^s v)(p^r u + p^s v)^t - p^x u u^t - p^y v v^t = p^e(uv^t + vu^t). \quad (3.9)$$

All three rank-one terms lie in L . Together with the diagonal rank-one forms, these identities generate L , without division by two. $\square$

Theorem 3.3 (All-degree graph saturation). *For a marked finite-etale graph presentation, every divided power of a class in its prescribed graph divisor lattice is an ordinary integral divisor product. Equivalently, after localization at p , the divided-power envelope of that lattice and its ordinary product image agree in every degree.*

Proof. After the unramified splitting extension, Lemmas 3.1 and 3.2 express every class in the extended graph divisor lattice as a finite sum $D = R_1 + \cdots + R_m$ of rank-one coefficient classes. These are classes in the coefficient extension of the original lattice, not newly descended line bundles. On the elliptic-power source the alternating form of each R_i has rank two, hence $R_i^2 = 0$. Pullback by the isogeny is injective on torsion-free cohomology, so the same identity holds on the quotient. Therefore

$$\frac{D^k}{k!} = \sum_{1 \leq i_1 < \cdots < i_k \leq m} R_{i_1} \cdots R_{i_k}, \quad (3.10)$$

an O' -linear combination of ordinary products over the splitting ring O' . More precisely,

$$P_{\text{gr}}^k \otimes_O O' = \text{im} \left(\text{Sym}^k(N_{\text{gr}} \otimes_O O') \longrightarrow H^{2k} \otimes_O O' \right).$$

Faithful flatness descends the quotient of these finite lattices, and hence descends (3.10) to O , and therefore to $\mathbf{Z}_p$ in the six-axis application. $\square$

The theorem concerns the divisor lattice selected by the marked elliptic-power presentation. If E has no complex multiplication, this is the full Neron–Severi lattice. At a CM fibre extra divisor classes need not satisfy the graph hypotheses. The statement is cohomological: it neither constructs Chow divided powers nor asserts that every integral Hodge class is a divisor product.

For comparison with the classical rational theory, Milne proves that the Lefschetz classes are the rational algebra generated by divisors [15, Theorem 3.2]. Divided powers in Chow and integral Fourier transforms are studied in [16, 3]. The local result above instead keeps the weighted integral graph lattice and the ordinary, rather than divided, product image.

3.2 The six-axis packet

We now apply the graph theorem to the polarization computed in Section 2.

We use the following elementary depth-one lifting observation. Let U be a unimodular O -lattice with symmetric Gram matrix B . Every endomorphism $\bar{T}$ of U/pU that is self-adjoint for B^{-1} has a lift $T \in \text{End}_O(U)$ satisfying

$$T^t B^{-1} = B^{-1} T. \quad (3.11)$$

The construction may be performed separately on orthogonal depth summands. Choose any lift T_0 . Its adjointness defect has the form

$$T_0^t B^{-1} - B^{-1} T_0 = pD,$$

where D is skew-symmetric with zero diagonal. Choose an integral matrix C with $C^t - C = -D$, for example by assigning its entries strictly above and below the diagonal. Then $T = T_0 + pBC$ reduces to $\bar{T}$, and

$$T^t B^{-1} - B^{-1} T = p(D + C^t - C) = 0.$$

No division by two is used. Applying the construction blockwise preserves the depth decomposition.

Lemma 3.4 (Local chart for the six-axis quotient). *Let $G = 6I_5 - J_5$. At each prime $p \mid 6$, the coefficient lattice has an orthogonal decomposition*

$$(\mathbf{Z}_p^5, G) \simeq U_0 \perp pU_1,$$

where U_0 has rank one and U_1 rank four, both unimodular. The principal quotient is trivial on U_0 . On U_1/pU_1 , its graph slope has minimal polynomial $t^2 + t + 1$ at $p = 2$; at $p = 3$ it is a scalar, hence a one-point finite-étale block, after choosing a complementary symplectic ruling if the selected half is vertical. In both cases the slope has a depth-preserving integral lift that is self-adjoint for the dual coefficient form, so these data give a marked finite-étale graph presentation.

Proof. Let $e_1, \dots, e_5$ be the standard basis. Since $\langle e_1, e_1 \rangle = 5$ and $\langle e_1, e_j \rangle = -1$, the vectors

$$v_j = e_j + \frac{1}{5}e_1 \quad (2 \leq j \leq 5)$$

span the orthogonal complement of e_1 over $\mathbf{Z}_p$. Its Gram matrix is $\frac{6}{5}(5I_4 - J_4)$, and $\det(5I_4 - J_4) = 5^3$. This gives the asserted unit line and depth-one block at two and three. The unit line contributes nothing to the p -primary discriminant group, so the p -primary isogeny kernel is supported entirely on U_1/pU_1 .

At two, Proposition 2.3 applies to every smooth fibre and identifies its geometric kernel with one of the two exotic graphs. Isotropy says that either slope is self-adjoint for the reduced dual form. It is a root in $\mathbf{F}_4$ of $t^2 + t + 1$, so its generated algebra is finite étale. The preceding lifting argument supplies the required integral self-adjoint lift on U_1 . At three, the same proposition says that every A_5 -stable half is a scalar graph because the coefficient heart is simple with commutant $\mathbf{F}_3$. More precisely, the four halves form $\mathbf{P}^1(\mathbf{F}_3)$. If the selected member is vertical, choose any other member as the complementary vertical ruling; the selected half then becomes the graph of a scalar (including zero). This change is only in the symplectic ruling of the primary kernel. The chosen symplectic basis of its two-dimensional multiplicity space lifts from $\mathbf{F}_3$ to $\mathbf{Z}_3$: equivalently, reduction $\mathrm{Sp}_2(\mathbf{Z}_3) \rightarrow \mathrm{Sp}_2(\mathbf{F}_3)$ is surjective. Thus it lifts to an integral change of ruling preserving the alternating form; the depth-one coefficient block and its scale $P = 3I$ are unchanged. The algebra generated by the resulting scalar is $\mathbf{F}_3$, hence is a one-point finite-étale block, and the same lifting argument applies. Extend each lift by a scalar on U_0 . No global choice of either slope is needed. $\square$

Theorem 3.5 (Divided powers for the six-axis family). *For every smooth member X_b of the nonstandard A_5 -cubic pencil, the prescribed six-axis graph divisor lattice on J_b has all its integral divided powers in the ordinary divisor-product image. In particular,*

$$\frac{\Theta_b^4}{4!} \in P_{J_b}^4. \quad (3.12)$$

Proof. Only the primes two and three occur in the Smith form $(1, 6, 6, 6, 6)$. Lemma 3.4 verifies the hypotheses of Theorem 3.3 at both primes. At every other prime the isogeny identifies the integral source and target lattices; equivalently the marked presentation has only its unit block $P = I$, so Theorem 3.3 applies trivially (or directly by Lemma 3.2). Thus the image of each desired divided power in the finitely generated quotient $H^{2k}(J_b, \mathbf{Z})/P_{J_b}^k$ vanishes after tensoring with $\mathbf{Z}_p$ for every prime p , and hence vanishes integrally. Finally, Lemma 2.2 gives $f_b^* \Theta_b = \lambda_{\mathcal{A}_b}$. The principal polarization is therefore one of the descended graph divisors defining the prescribed lattice, yielding (3.12). Extra Neron–Severi classes at a special fibre can only enlarge the ordinary product image needed for this last assertion. $\square$

Voisin identifies the primitive minimal class as the exact obstruction needed for cubic threefolds.

Corollary 3.6 (Universal CH_0 -triviality). *Every smooth member of the nonstandard A_5 -cubic pencil is universally CH_0 -trivial.*

Proof. By Theorem 3.5, the primitive minimal class of the intermediate Jacobian is algebraic. Voisin's Corollary 4.4 [18] says that, for a smooth complex cubic threefold, this is equivalent to universal CH_0 -triviality. $\square$

The argument is fibrewise. It constructs neither a horizontal minimal cycle over the pencil nor a relative decomposition of the diagonal. Neither is needed for Corollary 3.6.

4 Framed formal monodromy

The obstruction used here belongs to the small even quantum connection itself. We follow it through each blowup in a weak factorization, without passing to equivalence classes of quantum atoms. This avoids a subtlety: a formal bulk gauge is coefficientwise Laurent in the loop coordinate, but need not specialize to a meromorphic gauge at a nearby analytic point.

The proof has three stages. We first define the framed multiplicity ν_6 . We then prove its projective-bundle and blowup formulas, using divisor tags when the center Novikov map is not injective. Finally we show that centers of dimension at most two have $\nu_6 = 0$, so weak factorization makes ν_6 birationally invariant through dimension four.

Let T be a smooth projective variety. Write

$$\Lambda_T = \mathbf{C}[[\mathrm{NE}_{\mathrm{num}}^{\mathbf{Z}}(T)]]$$

for the completed monoid ring of the image of effective homology classes in the numerical curve lattice

$$N_1(T) = \mathrm{im}(H_2(T, \mathbf{Z}) \longrightarrow \mathrm{Hom}(\mathrm{NS}(T)/\mathrm{tors}, \mathbf{Z})).$$

Thus $N_1(T)$ is torsion-free and is separated by integral divisors. Let $\mathcal{K}_T$ be an algebraic closure of its fraction field. The loop coordinate z remains independent: in particular, $\mathcal{K}_T$ contains no chosen root of z . Apply the Levelt–Turrittin construction to the small even quantum connection over $\mathcal{K}_T((z))$. Its formal monodromy is the action of one turn on the original z -disc. Thus it includes both regular-singular monodromy and the deck permutation of ramified exponential factors.

Definition 4.1. Let $M_f(T)$ be this framed formal-monodromy operator, and put

$$\nu_6(T) = \mathrm{mult}_{e^{\pi i/3}} M_f(T) + \mathrm{mult}_{e^{-\pi i/3}} M_f(T).$$

The multiplicities are algebraic multiplicities in the characteristic polynomial.

The characteristic polynomial is unchanged by extending one algebraic closure of the numerical Novikov fraction field to a common overfield. Thus $\nu_6(T)$ is independent of that choice.

The frame matters. Adjoining roots of Novikov monomials is harmless, but adjoining a root of z would replace the original loop and could erase the deck part of the operator.

Definition 4.2 (Pro-Laurent framed monodromy). Let B be a complete separated multiplicatively filtered k -algebra, and let V be a finite-dimensional k -vector space. The pro-Laurent gauge group is

$$\mathcal{G}_{B,F}^{\mathrm{pro}}(V) = \varprojlim_N \mathrm{GL}(V \otimes (B/F^N B)((z))).$$

It is generally larger than $\mathrm{GL}(V \otimes B((z)))$, because the lower Laurent bound may decrease with N . For a compatible differential-module system over the quotients $B/F^N B$, its

framed-monodromy characteristic polynomial is the compatible system $(\chi_N)_N$ of finite-level polynomials, provided reduction sends χ_{N+1} to χ_N . Since B is complete and separated and the matrix rank is finite, this system is equivalently one polynomial over B . A pro-Laurent gauge preserves it if every finite-level gauge uses only integral powers of z .

We first record two formal facts used in the comparison theorems. They also fix the completion convention in the proof.

Lemma 4.3 (Coefficientwise base change). *Write $\partial = d/dz$. Let D be a formal differential module over $k((z))$, and let B be a complete separated I -adic k -algebra on which ∂ is zero. Fix a Levelt–Turrittin solution algebra R for D , with a fundamental solution matrix and differential constants $R^\partial = k$. Scalar extension in the coefficient direction preserves the characteristic polynomial of framed formal monodromy. The same holds after a connection gauge whose entries use only integral powers of z .*

Proof. At every finite level, the constants of $R \otimes_k B/I^N$ are B/I^N : expansion in a k -basis reduces this to $R^\partial = k$. A fundamental solution matrix then identifies the horizontal module with

$$\mathrm{Sol}(D) \otimes_k B/I^N.$$

Passing to the inverse limit gives $\mathrm{Sol}(D) \widehat{\otimes}_k B$, with monodromy $M_f(D) \otimes 1$. An integral- z gauge is single-valued on the original disc and conjugates this action. $\square$

Lemma 4.4 (Formal base shift). *Suppose a pullback of the even quantum connection of T is defined over a complete separated multiplicatively filtered $\mathbf{C}$ -algebra B , and its bulk coordinate has the form*

$$a_0 \mathbf{1} + a_2^\circ + \eta, \quad a_2^\circ \in H^2(T) \otimes F^0 B, \quad \eta \in F^1 B \widehat{\otimes} H^{\mathrm{ev}}(T).$$

Assume that a_0 and a_2° are constant in the positive filtration. Assume also that the units $e^{\langle a_2^\circ, d \rangle} \in B^\times$ are defined for numerical curve classes d , form a multiplicative character, and hence define the displayed continuous coefficient automorphism. Its framed formal-monodromy characteristic polynomial equals that of the small connection after the divisor substitution, coefficientwise in B ,

$$Q^d \longmapsto e^{\langle a_2^\circ, d \rangle} Q^d. \quad (4.1)$$

Proof. The string equation separates the rank-one exponential twist $\exp(-a_0/z)$. When a_0 is not filtration-nilpotent this twist need not belong to the pro-Laurent gauge group, but a full turn on the original z -disc fixes it, so its framed monodromy is trivial. The pro-Laurent gauge below is used only for the positive-filtration term η . The divisor equation gives (4.1). It remains to remove η , including its component in $H^2(T)$.

Modulo $F^N B$, the flat bulk equations

$$\partial_{\eta_i} G = -z^{-1}(\phi_i \star_\eta) G, \quad G|_{\eta=0} = 1,$$

are compatible because the even quantum connection is flat: the mixed derivatives of the quantum-product matrices agree, and those matrices commute by commutativity and associativity. To derive the Laurent bound, write $G = \sum_\alpha G_\alpha \eta^\alpha$. The coefficient of η^α in the i -th equation is

$$(\alpha_i + 1) G_{\alpha + e_i} = -z^{-1}[(\phi_i \star_\eta) G]_\alpha. \quad (4.1a)$$

The positive integer $\alpha_i + 1$ is invertible over $\mathbf{C}$. Strong induction on $|\alpha|$, with flatness making the choices of i consistent, gives the unique normalized solution; G_α contains no

power of z below $-|\alpha|$. Full flatness also makes the G -gauged z -connection independent of η ; at $\eta = 0$ it is the small connection, so G is the required connection gauge. After substituting η , a term of total bulk degree m lies in $F^m B$; modulo $F^N B$, only the finitely many degrees $m < N$ survive. The resulting finite sum is congruent to the identity modulo $F^1 B$, hence is invertible, and has a Laurent lower bound at least $-(N - 1)$. Uniqueness makes these solutions compatible in N . Their inverse limit belongs to

$$\mathcal{G}_{B,F}^{\text{pro}}(H^{\text{ev}}(T)). \quad (4.1b)$$

At each finite quotient the gauge uses only integral powers of z , hence is single-valued on the original disc. Lemma 4.3 makes the characteristic polynomial constant there. Compatibility of the finite-level solutions identifies these polynomials under every reduction map, so the hypothesis in Definition 4.2 is satisfied. Completeness and separatedness identify this compatible system with a polynomial over B ; its equality with the shifted small polynomial therefore survives every subsequent coefficient-field extension. No Levelt–Turrittin decomposition over a larger analytic field, and no evaluation at a nonnilpotent analytic bulk point, is used. $\square$

We now apply Iritani’s quantum blowup theorem and the Iritani–Koto projective-bundle theorem. Both are stated over completed homological Novikov rings. Iritani’s subsequent notes record explicitly that the blowup change of variables and decomposition preserve cohomological parity [11, Section 2].

Lemma 4.5 (Numerical Novikov base change). *The quotient from the effective homology monoid to its image in $N_1(T)$ extends continuously to completed monoid rings, and the quantum connection and the two comparison theorems base-change along it.*

Proof. Filter both monoids by intersection with an ample divisor. Effective homology classes below a fixed cutoff form a finite set, as follows from the finite-type Chow varieties of cycles of bounded degree. The quotient is therefore defined on every truncated monoid ring and passes to the inverse limit. Explicitly, the coefficient of $Q^{\vec{d}}$ in the image of $\sum_d a_d Q^d$ is

$$\sum_{d \rightarrow \vec{d}} a_d.$$

The sum is finite at every cutoff, and additivity of the quotient makes this coefficient-wise pushforward a unital homomorphism for completed convolution. Thus the quantum products descend by grouping Gromov–Witten coefficients with the same numerical class. Pushforward of curves, pairing with $c_1(N_{C/T})$, and the derivations $Q\partial_Q$ are constant on these fibres. At each cutoff, apply the resulting ring homomorphism to the comparison map and to its stated inverse. Scalar extension preserves their two inverse identities. Grouping coefficients identifies the scalar-extended quantum module with the numerical quantum module, and the preceding fiberwise constancy identifies its connection operators and divisor substitutions. Passing through the compatible cutoffs proves the asserted completed base change. $\square$

Proposition 4.6 (Framed operation formulas). *Let $V \rightarrow T$ be a vector bundle of rank $r \geq 2$. Then*

$$\nu_6(\mathbf{P}_T(V)) = r\nu_6(T). \quad (4.2)$$

Let $\tilde{T} = \text{Bl}_C T$, where $C \subset T$ is smooth of codimension $c \geq 2$. In Iritani’s comparison field one has

$$\nu_6(\tilde{T}) = \nu_6(T) + \sum_{j=0}^{c-2} \nu_6(C; \chi_j), \quad (4.3)$$

where χ_j is the numerical Novikov specialization of the j -th center summand. The endpoint terms in (4.3) are the intrinsic small invariants; the center terms are computed after the displayed specializations.

Proof. Iritani's Theorem 5.18 gives a formal coordinate isomorphism and a quantum- D -module isomorphism

$$\mathrm{QDM}(\tilde{T}) \cong \mathrm{QDM}(T) \oplus \mathrm{QDM}(C)^{\oplus(c-1)}$$

over a Laurent extension in the exceptional Novikov variable [10, Theorem 5.18]. The isomorphism and its inverse use only integral powers of z , and the mirror coordinates are independent of z . The comparison field adjoins q^{-1/s_c} , where $s_c = c - 1$ for even c and $s_c = 2(c - 1)$ for odd c ; this is only a coefficient extension. The reconstruction coordinate below is $u = q^{-1/(c-1)}$. The center base shift is controlled before passage to the final Laurent chart. Put $u = q^{-1/(c-1)}$ and use the reconstruction coordinates of [10, Section 5.8.2]:

$$\varsigma_j = \varsigma_j^\circ + s_j, \quad \varsigma_j^\circ = -(c-1)\lambda_j + h_{C,j} + O(u). \quad (4.4)$$

For the j -th target summand, let R_j be the image of $Q_C^d \mapsto Q^{i_*d} u^{\rho_C \cdot d}$, together with u and s_j , and set

$$\begin{aligned} J_j &= (u, \{Q^{i_*d} u^{\rho_C \cdot d} : d \neq 0\}, \text{components of } s_j) \subset R_j, \\ B_j &= \varprojlim_N R_j / J_j^N, \quad F^N B_j = \ker(B_j \rightarrow R_j / J_j^N). \end{aligned}$$

Here R_j is a subring of the Laurent monoid domain occurring in the comparison chart, and B_j is, by construction, complete and separated for the multiplicative inverse-limit filtration $F^\bullet B_j$. Reduction $B_j / F^{N+1} B_j \rightarrow B_j / F^N B_j$ preserves the connection formulas. The center connection is defined over this image ring by [10, Remark 5.6]. Formula (4.4), together with (5.45), (5.47), and the initial asymptotics (5.27)–(5.30), shows that after the unit term $-(c-1)\lambda_j$ and fixed divisor $h_{C,j}$ are removed, its target bulk coordinate lies in $J_j H^*(C)$. The noninjective center monomial map merely replaces the source ring by its image.

First separate the single-valued rank-one exponential twist associated with $-(c-1)\lambda_j$, and apply the fixed divisor shift. The normalized connection descends to B_j . Apply Lemma 4.4 modulo every J_j^N . Uniqueness of the normalized solution makes the gauges, and hence their characteristic polynomials, compatible under all reductions. No embedding of the abstract completion B_j into a Laurent field is used. Instead let S_j denote Iritani's completed Laurent comparison ring and base-change at every finite stage along the canonical map

$$R_j / J_j^N \longrightarrow S_j / (J_j S_j)^N.$$

The formal coefficient maps defining Ψ and Ψ^{-1} are continuous for this Novikov–bulk filtration, so their inverse identities and the connection intertwining descend to these finite quotients and are compatible in N . Taking their inverse limit gives the comparison directly over S_j . Theorem 5.18 supplies both maps there with only integral powers of z , so they preserve the framed characteristic polynomial on the original disc. The fixed-divisor substitution is a z -constant coefficient automorphism, so it does not change ν_6 ; it is well defined on the image because $h_{C,j}$ is a scalar multiple of ρ_C . Thus each center target summand has the framed monodromy of its specialized small connection. The ambient target uses $\tau = \tau^\circ + t$, with $\tau^\circ = O(q^{-1})$, and the same finite-quotient argument. Direct-sum additivity gives (4.3).

The endpoint map is faithful: on numerical curve lattices

$$\bar{\beta} \longmapsto (\phi_* \bar{\beta}, -E \cdot \bar{\beta})$$

is injective because $N^1(\tilde{T}) = \phi^* N^1(T) \oplus \mathbf{Z}[E]$. Hence the Laurent extension preserves the intrinsic endpoint characteristic polynomials.

The projective-bundle proof is parallel, again in reconstruction coordinates. Its comparison field adjoins $q^{-1/r'}$, with $r' = r$ when $r - 1$ is even and $r' = 2r$ when $r - 1$ is odd; the reconstruction coordinate remains $u = q^{-1/r}$. The extra root is again a coefficient extension. Put $u = q^{-1/r}$. For its j -th target summand let R_j be the image of $Q_T^d \mapsto Q^{d u^{c_1(V) \cdot d}}$, together with u and s_j , and set

$$J_j = (u, \{Q^{d u^{c_1(V) \cdot d}} : d \neq 0\}, \text{components of } s_j) \subset R_j,$$

$$B_j = \varprojlim_N R_j / J_j^N, \quad F^N B_j = \ker(B_j \rightarrow R_j / J_j^N).$$

Again R_j is a subring of the relevant Laurent monoid domain and B_j is complete and separated for its multiplicative inverse-limit filtration $F^\bullet B_j$. Formula (5.11) places the normalized target coordinate in $J_j H^{\text{ev}}(T)$, and the displayed exponent shows that the fixed-divisor substitution factors through the image monoid. Theorem 5.1, Proposition 5.6, and Section 5.8 of Iritani–Koto give

$$\varsigma_j = \varsigma_j^\circ + s_j, \quad \varsigma_j^\circ = r \lambda_j - \frac{2\pi i j}{r} c_1(V) + O(u).$$

This is Theorem 5.1, Proposition 5.6, and Section 5.8, especially (5.11), of [12]. Separate the Laurent unit as a single-valued rank-one exponential twist and apply the fixed divisor shift first. The normalized connection descends to B_j ; apply Lemma 4.4 in its finite quotients. Uniqueness makes the gauges and characteristic polynomials compatible under reduction. As in the blowup case, write S_j for the completed Laurent comparison ring and use the compatible finite-stage maps $R_j / J_j^N \rightarrow S_j / (J_j S_j)^N$; no map from the abstract completion into a field is asserted. The formal comparison maps and their inverse identities are continuous for this filtration, so they descend at every stage and pass to the inverse limit over S_j . Theorem 5.1 and Proposition 5.6 provide these mutually inverse maps using integral powers of z , so the framed characteristic polynomial is preserved. Again the divisor substitution is a z -constant coefficient automorphism; it factors through the displayed u -exponent. This gives r copies of the intrinsic base module and proves (4.2). The base Novikov map is the embedding in [12, (1.1) and Remark 5.2]. The theorem assumes $V^\vee$ globally generated. Tensoring V by a sufficiently negative line bundle achieves this without changing $\mathbf{P}_T(V)$ [12, Remark 1.2]; the resulting divisor shift preserves framed monodromy by Lemma 4.4. All other Novikov extensions are in the coefficient direction. After the odd bulk variables vanish, pullback, pushforward, Fourier transformation, and multiplication by the characteristic-class factors all preserve cohomological parity. Hence both decompositions restrict to the even quantum connections used here. Formula (4.2) is tautological when $r = 1$. $\square$

The center map in (4.3) is not necessarily injective [10, (5.15)]. Thus generic vanishing for C does not by itself imply that its specialized term vanishes. The next lemma supplies the missing implication.

Definition 4.7. A monomial map $\chi : \Lambda_T \rightarrow A$ is *strictly Novikov-admissible* if A is a complete separated valued domain with domain associated graded, every monomial has nonzero image, and

$$v(\chi(Q^d)) = \ell(d), \tag{4.5}$$

where ℓ is positive and proper on the effective numerical monoid.

We write $\nu_6(T; \chi)$ for the framed small-even invariant after scalar extension along such a map.

The center maps in (4.3) are strictly admissible. Give the exceptional Laurent variable valuation zero and use an ample divisor H on T . Then

$$v_H(Q^{i \cdot d} q^{-\rho_C \cdot d / (c-1)}) = (H|_C) \cdot d.$$

The restriction $H|_C$ is ample, which gives positivity and properness; the associated graded Laurent monoid ring is a domain.

Lemma 4.8 (Divisor tagging). *Let $\chi : \Lambda_T \rightarrow A$ be strictly Novikov-admissible. If the intrinsic small even quantum connection of T has no primitive-sixth framed monodromy, neither does its specialization along χ .*

Proof. If $N_1(T) = 0$, then the numerical effective monoid is $\{0\}$, so the coefficient map is already injective and there is nothing to tag. Assume otherwise. Choose integral divisors $D_1, \dots, D_\rho$ whose pairings separate $N_1(T)$, and introduce formal variables $\mathbf{t} = (t_1, \dots, t_\rho)$. Define

$$\chi_{\mathbf{t}}(Q^d) = \chi(Q^d) \exp\left(\sum_i t_i (D_i \cdot d)\right). \quad (4.6)$$

This map from Λ_T to $A[[\mathbf{t}]]$ is injective. To prove this, take a nonzero series. Properness in (4.5) makes its lowest-valuation support finite. Its initial image is a finite combination of distinct exponential characters. The finitely many exponent vectors are distinct integral vectors. Choose $a = (a_i) \in \mathbf{Z}^\rho$ outside the finitely many integral hyperplanes on which two dot products agree, and substitute $t_i = a_i s$. The resulting exponents are distinct integers. Their derivatives at $s = 0$ form a Vandermonde matrix with nonzero integer determinant, which remains invertible in the characteristic-zero fraction field. The characters are therefore linearly independent. The domain hypothesis on the associated graded prevents cancellation of the initial terms.

Let $k_\chi = \overline{\text{Frac } A}$. After embedding the two fraction fields in a common algebraic closure, injectivity makes the $\chi_{\mathbf{t}}$ -module a scalar extension of the intrinsic module. On the other hand, the divisor equation identifies (4.6) with the degree-two formal bulk pullback of the χ -module over $B = k_\chi[[\mathbf{t}]]$. Apply the finite-quotient argument in Lemma 4.4 with $\eta = \sum_i t_i D_i$: its integral- z bulk gauge removes the positive divisor component. Hence vanishing over the intrinsic field implies vanishing after χ . $\square$

Proposition 4.9 (Low-dimensional vanishing). *Let T be a point, a smooth projective curve, or a smooth projective surface. For every strictly Novikov-admissible specialization χ ,*

$$\nu_6(T; \chi) = 0. \quad (4.7)$$

Proof. We first prove the intrinsic generic statement. If K_T is nef, the proof of [13, Claim 6.15] applies coefficient by coefficient over the small numerical Novikov ring. Set

$$\text{Gr} = \frac{\text{Deg} - \dim T}{2}, \quad g = \text{Gr} + \frac{1}{2}E,$$

where E is the identity in cohomological degrees of parity opposite to $\dim T$ and is zero in the other degrees. The operator g has integral eigenvalues. Coefficientwise in Q^β , multiplication by $c_1(T)$ sends

$$H^i(T) \longrightarrow H^{i+2-2c_1(T) \cdot \beta}(T).$$

If K_T is nef, then $c_1(T) \cdot \beta \leq 0$, so the Gr-weight rises by $1 - c_1(T) \cdot \beta \geq 1$. Conjugation by z^g therefore turns $\nabla + \frac{1}{2}E dz/z$ into a regular-singular connection with nilpotent residue. Undoing the half-parity correction permits only the monodromy eigenvalues 1 and -1 : quantum multiplication preserves cohomological parity, so the parity operator commutes with the transformed nilpotent residue. A primitive sixth root cannot occur.

This treats curves of positive genus and minimal surfaces with nef canonical class. A point is immediate. The remaining minimal varieties are $\mathbf{P}^1$, $\mathbf{P}^2$, and ruled surfaces; (4.2) reduces them to a point or a curve. Every nonminimal surface is obtained from a minimal surface by point blowups, and (4.3) adds only point summands. Hence the intrinsic generic invariant vanishes in every case. Lemma 4.8 gives (4.7). $\square$

Theorem 4.10 (Birational invariance through dimension four). *If Y and Y' are birational smooth projective complex varieties of the same dimension at most four, then*

$$\nu_6(Y) = \nu_6(Y'). \quad (4.8)$$

Consequently, for smooth projective threefolds,

$$Y \times \mathbf{P}^1 \dashrightarrow Y' \times \mathbf{P}^1 \implies \nu_6(Y) = \nu_6(Y').$$

Proof. Weak factorization decomposes a birational map between smooth varieties into blowups and blowdowns with smooth centers of codimension at least two [1]. In dimension at most four every nontrivial center has dimension at most two. The calculation following Definition 4.7 shows that every center specialization in (4.3) is strictly admissible. Proposition 4.9 therefore makes every center term zero, so the endpoint values agree at each step.

If Y, Y' are smooth threefolds and $Y \times \mathbf{P}^1 \dashrightarrow Y' \times \mathbf{P}^1$, apply the first assertion in dimension four and (4.2):

$$2\nu_6(Y) = \nu_6(Y \times \mathbf{P}^1) = \nu_6(Y' \times \mathbf{P}^1) = 2\nu_6(Y').$$

Cancelling two in $\mathbf{Z}$ proves the stabilization assertion. $\square$

Proposition 4.11 (The cubic packet). *For every smooth cubic threefold X ,*

$$\nu_6(X) = 2. \quad (4.9)$$

Proof. In the basis $1, P, P^2, P^3$, Cai explicitly block-diagonalizes the small even quantum connection. The rank-two zero-exponential block has indicial polynomial

$$\rho^2 + \rho + \frac{5}{36},$$

with roots $-1/6$ and $-5/6$ [4, Section 3, pp. 5–6]. His gauge uses only integral powers of z . The two corresponding framed-monodromy eigenvalues are $e^{-\pi i/3}$ and $e^{\pi i/3}$. The two remaining rank-one even blocks are displayed as exponentials in z^{-1} times series in nonnegative integral powers of z [4, pp. 5–7]; their framed-monodromy factor is therefore 1, so they contribute no primitive sixth root. Thus the multiplicity is exactly two. By definition, ν_6 uses the small even connection, so no odd-cohomology block enters this count. The numerical curve lattice of a cubic threefold has rank one, so the numerical-Novikov convention does not change the calculation. $\square$

Proof of Theorem 1.2. The projective-bundle formula and Proposition 4.11 give

$$\nu_6(X \times \mathbf{P}^1) = 2\nu_6(X) > 0. \quad (4.10)$$

Suppose that $X \times \mathbf{P}^1$ were rational. By Theorem 4.10,

$$\nu_6(X \times \mathbf{P}^1) = \nu_6(\mathbf{P}^4) = 0,$$

where the last equality follows from (4.2) over a point. This contradicts (4.10). $\square$

4.1 A genus-eight Fano consequence

Kuznetsov associates to every smooth prime Fano threefold V of genus eight a smooth Pfaffian cubic threefold X , together with rank-two vector bundles U on V and E^* on X , whose projectivizations are related by a flop [14, Theorems 2.17–2.18].

Corollary 4.12 (One stabilization of V_{14}). *For every smooth prime Fano threefold V of genus eight,*

$$\nu_6(V) = 2, \quad V \times \mathbf{P}^1 \text{ is irrational.} \quad (4.11)$$

Proof. The flop gives a birational map between the smooth projective fourfolds $\mathbf{P}_V(U)$ and $\mathbf{P}_X(E^*)$. By Theorem 4.10, Proposition 4.6, and Proposition 4.11,

$$2\nu_6(V) = \nu_6(\mathbf{P}_V(U)) = \nu_6(\mathbf{P}_X(E^*)) = 2\nu_6(X) = 4.$$

Hence $\nu_6(V) = 2$. Formula (4.2) now gives $\nu_6(V \times \mathbf{P}^1) = 4$, whereas every rational smooth fourfold has $\nu_6 = 0$ by Theorem 4.10. $\square$

The argument is sharp for this invariant. In a factorization of the fivefold $X \times \mathbf{P}^2$, a center may have dimension three and may itself carry the cubic packet. The next stabilization therefore requires information about the packet's Stokes or Rees placement, not only its multiplicity.

5 The separation theorem

Proof of Theorem 1.1. Corollary 3.6 gives universal CH_0 -triviality of X_b . The projective bundle formula for Chow groups gives the same property for $X_b \times \mathbf{P}^1$. Theorem 1.2 proves that this fourfold is irrational. Non-isotriviality follows from the nonconstant intermediate-Jacobian period map on the A_5 -component: Hartlieb proves that the closure of its image is a one-dimensional special subvariety [8, Proposition 5.7]. $\square$

The algebraic class $\Theta^4/4!$ removes the decomposition-of-diagonal obstruction, while the primitive-sixth framed-monodromy multiplicity survives one stabilization and obstructs a rational factorization. The A_5 -family is where these conclusions hold simultaneously.

The two detectors are independent already on smooth projective threefolds. If $U(Y)$ is the indicator of universal CH_0 -triviality, then

$$(U(Y), \nu_6(Y)) = \begin{cases} (1, 0), & Y = \mathbf{P}^3, \\ (1, 2), & Y \text{ is a smooth member of the family above,} \\ (0, 2), & Y \text{ is a very general cubic threefold.} \end{cases}$$

The last line follows from the evenness theorem for algebraic curve classes on the very general intermediate Jacobian together with Voisin's criterion [6, Theorem 1.3 and Corollary 1.4][18, Corollary 4.4]. Thus neither universal CH_0 -triviality nor ν_6 determines the other.

For $X \times \mathbf{P}^m$ with $m \geq 2$, weak-factorization centers may have dimension at least three and can carry primitive-sixth quantum packets. The low-dimensional vanishing in Proposition 4.9 no longer proves noncancellation. Likewise, the fibrewise minimal-class argument gives no relative universal cycle over the pencil. These are separate problems and are not implicit in the theorem above.

Vanishing of the decomposition-of-the-diagonal obstruction therefore does not predict rationality after one explicit stabilization.

References

- [1] D. Abramovich, K. Karu, K. Matsuki, and J. Włodarczyk, *Torification and factorization of birational maps*, J. Amer. Math. Soc. 15 (2002), 531–572.
- [2] J. D. Achter, S. Casalaina-Martin, and J. Wise, *Images of abelian schemes*, preprint, arXiv:2312.13262v2 (2024).
- [3] T. Beckmann and O. de Gaay Fortman, *Integral Fourier transforms and the integral Hodge conjecture for one-cycles on abelian varieties*, Compos. Math. 159 (2023), 1188–1213.
- [4] J. Cai, *The cubic threefold is symplectically irrational*, arXiv:2608.01577 (2026).
- [5] C. H. Clemens and P. A. Griffiths, *The intermediate Jacobian of the cubic threefold*, Ann. of Math. (2) 95 (1972), 281–356.
- [6] P. Engel, O. de Gaay Fortman, and S. Schreieder, *Matroids and the integral Hodge conjecture for abelian varieties*, arXiv:2507.15704v3 (2026).
- [7] N. Grieve, *Reduced norms and the Riemann–Roch theorem for abelian varieties*, New York J. Math. 23 (2017), 1087–1110; arXiv:1603.06425.
- [8] M. Hartlieb, *Special subvarieties in the locus of intermediate Jacobians of cubic threefolds*, Math. Z. 310 (2025), article 52; arXiv:2304.03214.
- [9] K. Jansen, K. Lux, R. Parker, and R. Wilson, *An atlas of Brauer characters*, London Mathematical Society Monographs, New Series 11, Oxford University Press, 1995; see also the A_5 representation table, version 3.004, especially the matrix rows with characteristic/ring/dimension/ID $2/\mathrm{GF}(4)/2/a, b$, $2/\mathrm{GF}(2)/4/a, b$, and $3/\mathrm{GF}(3)/4$, at <https://brauer.maths.qmul.ac.uk/Atlas/v3/alt/A5/>.
- [10] H. Iritani, *Quantum cohomology of blowups*, arXiv:2307.13555v3 (2025).
- [11] H. Iritani, *Notes on the decomposition theorem for blowups*, arXiv:2604.10028 (2026).
- [12] H. Iritani and Y. Koto, *Quantum cohomology of projective bundles*, arXiv:2307.03696v4 (2026).
- [13] L. Katzarkov, M. Kontsevich, T. Pantev, and T. Y. Yu, *Birational invariants from Hodge structures and quantum multiplication*, arXiv:2508.05105v2 (2026).
- [14] A. Kuznetsov, *Derived categories of cubic and V_{14} threefolds*, Proc. Steklov Inst. Math. 246 (2004), 171–194; arXiv:math/0303037.
- [15] J. S. Milne, *Lefschetz classes on abelian varieties*, Duke Math. J. 96 (1999), 639–675.
- [16] B. Moonen and A. Polishchuk, *Divided powers in Chow rings and integral Fourier transforms*, Adv. Math. 224 (2010), 2216–2236.
- [17] X. Roulleau, *Genus 2 curve configurations on Fano surfaces*, Comment. Math. Univ. St. Pauli 59 (2010), 51–64; arXiv:1002.4467.
- [18] C. Voisin, *On the universal CH_0 group of cubic hypersurfaces*, J. Eur. Math. Soc. 19 (2017), 1619–1653; arXiv:1407.7261.
- [19] J. Yu, *Tropicalizing the positive semidefinite cone*, Proc. Amer. Math. Soc. 143 (2015), 1891–1895.